Capstone: prepare a customer discovery summary

Prepare a discovery summary for a fictional online retailer. Bring together customer research, cloud needs, discovery questions, sales materials and CRM-style notes. The final project is the practical task inside this capstone activity.

You are an entry-level sales associate in a cloud sales organisation. Your manager wants a short discovery summary before the team's first customer meeting. Use the supplied case as your research source. You do not need to find this fictional company online, open a cloud account or build a technical solution.

This is practice, with a self-review and a worked example. Your written responses are not submitted or automatically graded. The separate final course quiz remains the course's graded assessment.

Allow about 45 minutes. Complete the five tasks, check your reasoning, then compare with the worked example. Write in your own document or the supplied workbook. Use the Opportunities tab. Keep a copy of your work; it is not submitted for grading.

Company and customers

Sto Lat Select is a fictional, mid-sized e-commerce retailer founded in 2016. It sells lifestyle and home goods, including home decor, small appliances and personalised accessories. It has about 250 employees, no physical shops, and customers in the United States, Canada and parts of Western Europe. It plans to expand internationally.

How it operates

All sales go through its website. A small engineering team maintains on-premises servers and connects the storefront to email marketing, customer analytics, payments, inventory and order-management tools. Marketing uses personalised recommendations, email campaigns, seasonal promotions and social advertising. Customer support uses separate chat, tracking and feedback systems.

Peak traffic

Promotions, holiday shopping and influencer campaigns cause traffic spikes. The current infrastructure cannot increase capacity quickly. The case reports slower pages, checkout delays, occasional outages and additional work on patching and capacity management. The case does not quantify the frequency, cost or duration of those problems.

Customer information

Customer data is spread across five or more systems. Profiles are inconsistent, staff make manual exports, and personalisation is limited. Leadership wants a clearer view of customers and buying behaviour. Teams also find it difficult to report on customer value, repeat purchases, product recommendations and inventory needs.

Growth and protection

International expansion brings additional data-protection, payment-security and regional compliance questions. The team is concerned about patching, access controls, sensitive data and audit records. Cloud adoption alone would not establish compliance; the team would need to investigate responsibilities and controls.

Priorities and unknowns

Over the next 12–18 months, leadership wants more reliable website performance, better customer insights, less maintenance work and support for safe growth. It is exploring cloud options but has not started a formal evaluation. The case gives no confirmed budget, decision maker, migration deadline, agreed service choice or measured savings. Treat those as questions, not facts.

Cloud capability reference

Traffic peaks and slow pages

Capacity that can increase or decrease with demand; load balancing and availability options. Investigate workload, performance targets and application design.

Fragmented customer information

Data integration, managed storage and analytics capabilities. Investigate data quality, access and consent before proposing consolidation.

Backup and recovery needs

Backup, storage redundancy and disaster-recovery options. Establish recovery needs and responsibilities; do not assume a backup policy exists.

Security and access concerns

Encryption, identity and access management, monitoring and audit capabilities. Identify requirements and shared responsibilities with a technical colleague.

Maintenance and cost concerns

Managed services and usage-based charging may change the work and costs involved. Confirm usage, migration effort and support needs before claiming savings.

Profile the customer

Write one or two short paragraphs describing Sto Lat Select's operations, digital presence and main challenges. Use only facts supplied in the case. Explain why those facts matter for the first customer conversation.

Workbook mapping: Company profile and Needs / Challenges

- I have described the online-only business and its customers.
- I have connected two or more case facts to discovery priorities.
- I have not invented customer research, figures or decision makers.

Identify possible cloud needs

Choose two or three needs grounded in the case. For each, connect a customer problem to a possible cloud capability and explain what you would need to confirm. You are preparing for discovery, not selecting a provider or designing architecture.

Workbook mapping: Needs / Challenges and Win plan summary

- Each need comes from the supplied case.
- I have explained the business relevance of a possible capability.
- I have named a question or limitation instead of guaranteeing a result.

Prepare the conversation

Write three to five open discovery questions. Ask about the customer's priorities, impact, current approach and readiness. Give the customer room to explain rather than steering them to a particular product.

Workbook mapping: Win plan summary

- My questions invite an explanation rather than a yes/no answer.
- They connect to the customer's actual situation.
- They help clarify unknowns without assuming an agreed solution.

Prepare your first-meeting pack

Choose an opening priority, select two case facts and adapt one of the supplied visuals for the first customer meeting. Review a draft claim and add your own message, discovery question and next action. Use an internal guide to prepare the team. Your pack can then support the CRM handover.

Workbook mapping: Notes

- I can explain how my selected facts support the opening priority.
- My message and question suit the customer conversation; internal preparation stays separate.
- I have reviewed the draft claim, checked the feedback and identified what needs confirming.

Leave a usable handover

Bring your work into a concise CRM-style handover. Include the company, needs and challenges, important unknowns, discovery questions, suitable materials and a realistic next action. You can write here or use the downloadable workbook's Opportunities tab. Unused fields may remain blank or N/A; record unconfirmed information as unknown.

Workbook mapping: Needs / Challenges; Internal alignment plan; Win plan summary; Next steps; Notes

- A colleague can distinguish supplied facts from possible explanations and proposed actions.
- The handover includes questions and an achievable next step.
- I have kept budget, authority and timing unknown where the case provides no confirmation.

Task 4 meeting materials

Your colleague is opening the first customer meeting. Choose an opening priority and two supporting case facts. Adapt a supplied visual into a meeting aid, review a draft claim, and prepare a question and next action. More than one opening priority can be justified.

Handling promotional traffic

Use this visual to explore where a promotion affects the buying journey.

Visual sequence: Promotion brings a traffic spike. Then: Website pages slow. Then: Checkout delays or outages.

Explore capacity that adjusts with demand and suitable load balancing.

Confirm workload, performance targets and application constraints. This is an investigation, not an agreed design.

Colleague's draft claim to review: Flexible capacity will resolve the checkout delays without changes to the application.

Making customer information usable

Use this visual to explore what prevents teams from using consistent customer information.

Visual sequence: Records in 5+ systems. Then: Inconsistent profiles and manual exports. Then: Difficult customer reporting.

Explore data integration and analytics to support the reports teams need.

Check ownership, quality, access and consent before proposing a joined view. Integration alone does not correct inaccurate records.

Colleague's draft claim to review: Bringing the records together will give every team a complete, accurate customer view.

Supporting case facts: choose two

- All sales go through the website; there are no physical shops. Case section: Company and customers; How it operates.
- Promotions cause traffic spikes, slower pages, checkout delays and occasional outages. Case section: Peak traffic.
- A small engineering team maintains the servers and handles patching and capacity work. Case section: How it operates; Peak traffic.
- Customer data is spread across five or more systems, with inconsistent profiles. Case section: Customer information.
- Staff make manual exports and find customer-value and repeat-purchase reporting difficult. Case section: Customer information.
- Leadership wants a clearer view of customers and buying behaviour. Case section: Customer information.

Cost and disruption preparation

Internal meeting notes for the sales team. Use them to prepare questions, not as a statement of customer commitments.

- Ask which operational work is most difficult during a promotion and what a disruption affects.

- Ask what changes would need testing, what support the small engineering team would need and who should assess the application.
- Explore current effort, usage and migration work before claiming a saving. Bring unresolved technical questions to a colleague with the relevant expertise.

Customer information readiness

Internal reference for preparing an accurate follow-up about fragmented information.

- Data integration connects information from different systems. First establish which records and reports people need.
- Consistent reporting also depends on data quality and ownership. Connecting inconsistent records does not automatically fix them.
- Confirm access, consent and retention requirements. Identify who can explain the current data and involve a technical colleague before recommending a design.

Build and review your pack

Choose an opening priority and a visual. Select two supporting facts. Write an opening message, a discovery question and your next action with a reason for this priority. Decide whether to use, qualify or omit the draft claim, and explain what you would change or confirm. Select an internal guide.

Review guidance: use after your first attempt

Handling promotional traffic: Capacity is relevant, but the case does not establish the cause of every delay or whether the application can use extra capacity effectively. Confirm workload and application constraints before making that claim.

One bounded alternative: Capacity that adjusts with demand may help with peak traffic. We would first check where delays occur and what changes the application would need.

Making customer information usable: Connecting records does not establish their accuracy or give every team permission to use them. Clarify data quality, ownership, access and intended reports before promising a complete view.

One bounded alternative: A joined view may help teams report more consistently. We would first check which records they need, their quality and who should have access.

- Does your opening message explain why this issue matters to this customer?
- Does the question invite evidence you do not already have, rather than ask the customer to approve a product?
- Does your next action say what you would confirm and why this priority should lead the conversation?

Both opening priorities can be justified. If your facts or visual point to a different issue, explain the link or reconsider the priority. Keep proposed capabilities separate from confirmed outcomes. Add the pack notes to your CRM handover while retaining your earlier work.

Self-review questions

1. Which details belong in the company profile? Select two.

- A. Its online-only sales model and digital marketing activity.
- B. An estimated technology budget that is not given in the case.
- C. Its reported peak-traffic and fragmented-data problems.
- D. A named decision maker inferred from the company's size.

2. Why identify possible cloud needs before choosing a service?

- A. To make a product shortlist before discussing customer priorities.
- B. To connect a capability to a business problem and identify what still needs confirming.
- C. To replace the technical colleague's later requirements review.
- D. To turn the customer's growth plans into a confirmed migration commitment.

3. Which capabilities are worth investigating for promotion-related traffic problems? Select two.

- A. Capacity that can adjust as demand changes.
- B. A fixed capacity commitment chosen without traffic information.
- C. Suitable availability and load-balancing options.
- D. A customer analytics report used as the sole reliability measure.

4. What should the team clarify before recommending customer-data consolidation?

- A. Whether the company's employee count will stay exactly the same.
- B. Which provider's branding should appear on the recommendation.
- C. Whether every customer record can be retained indefinitely.
- D. Which data people need, who owns it, its quality and the access requirements.

5. Which questions support open discovery? Select two.

- A. Would you like us to select a cloud package now?
- B. Which reporting difficulty has the greatest effect on your team's decisions?
- C. What concerns would you need addressed before evaluating a change?
- D. Can we assume the engineering lead has already approved the move?

6. Which material uses fit an early discovery conversation? Select two.

- A. A full implementation proposal presented as already approved.
- B. The internal cost and disruption guide for preparing questions about operational effort and change.
- C. A customer-specific price guarantee based on no usage information.
- D. The customer information readiness guide for preparing accurate follow-up questions.

7. What is the main purpose of the CRM-style handover?

- A. To turn possible cloud opportunities into confirmed deal facts.
- B. To give a colleague usable context, known information, open questions and next actions.
- C. To replace the original case with a longer account history.
- D. To demonstrate that every available CRM column has been populated.

8. What should remain explicitly unconfirmed in this record? Select two.

- A. The company sells online.
- B. The customer's budget and decision authority.
- C. The case reports fragmented customer information.
- D. An agreed migration deadline and expected savings.

9. Which statement is suitably bounded for this stage?

- A. Managed services will remove the engineering team's operational responsibilities.
- B. Cloud adoption will establish the retailer's compliance with regional requirements.
- C. The team could investigate capacity and data capabilities, then validate fit and responsibilities.
- D. A provider can be selected because the case mentions international growth.

10. How should you use the worked example?

- A. Compare the reasoning with your own work, identify gaps and revise your handover.
- B. Copy its exact wording so every learner produces the same response.
- C. Treat its proposed actions as additional customer facts.
- D. Use it as proof that a real customer accepted the proposed cloud direction.

Self-review answers and feedback

Question 1: A, C

Correct. The sales model and reported problems are supplied case facts. Budget and decision authority remain unknown.

Revisit hint: Review Company and customers, Peak traffic and Priorities and unknowns. Separate supplied facts from assumptions.

Question 2: B

Correct. Discovery connects problems to possible capabilities while keeping requirements and assumptions open for confirmation.

Revisit hint: Review Identify possible cloud needs. Consider the distinction between discovery and an agreed recommendation.

Question 3: A, C

Correct. Elastic capacity and appropriate availability options are relevant to investigate. Their effectiveness depends on workload, design and requirements.

Revisit hint: Review the Traffic peaks and slow pages capability note. Ask which options address capacity and availability.

Question 4: D

Correct. Ownership, quality, access and intended use must be clarified before consolidation can be recommended.

Revisit hint: Review Customer information and the integration/analytics capability note. Consider what makes information usable and appropriate to share.

Question 5: B, C

Correct. These questions invite priorities and concerns. They do not presume approval or a product choice.

Revisit hint: Review Prepare the conversation. Look for questions that invite the customer's explanation without presuming a decision.

Question 6: B, D

Correct. Both references support preparation. They do not establish a final design, price or customer commitment.

Revisit hint: Review Prepare your first-meeting pack and its internal guides. Match the stage of the conversation to the use of the material.

Question 7: B

Correct. A useful record helps the next colleague continue the work and distinguish facts, unknowns and actions.

Revisit hint: Review Leave a usable handover. Think about what the next colleague needs in order to continue responsibly.

Question 8: B, D

Correct. The case does not establish budget, authority, a migration deadline or savings. The sales model and data problems are provided.

Revisit hint: Review Priorities and unknowns. A growth-planning horizon is not automatically a migration commitment.

Question 9: C

Correct. The proposal is to investigate and validate. Responsibilities, compliance and service fit are not established by the case alone.

Revisit hint: Review the capability notes and Growth and protection. Distinguish a possible investigation from an established result.

Question 10: A

Correct. Different responses can be sound when they use the case accurately, explain their reasoning and preserve uncertainty.

Revisit hint: Review your task checklists. The example shows a possible response to a fictional case, rather than a customer-approved solution.

The worked examples below show one possible response. Compare their reasoning with your own work and preserve the difference between facts, unknowns and proposed actions.

Worked example: Profile the customer

Sto Lat Select is an online-only retailer of lifestyle and home goods with about 250 employees. Its website and digital marketing support all sales, so the traffic-related delays and occasional outages described in the case are relevant discovery topics.

Its customer information is spread across several systems and reporting requires manual work. Leadership is exploring cloud options to support growth, customer insights and more reliable operations. Budget, decision authority and a migration deadline have not yet been confirmed.

Worked example: Identify possible cloud needs

1. Website reliability during promotions: capacity that can adjust with demand and suitable availability options may help. Confirm traffic patterns, the application's constraints and acceptable interruption before making a recommendation.

2. Customer information and reporting: integration and analytics capabilities may help teams use consistent information. Confirm data ownership, quality, access and the reports people need.

3. Maintenance and protection: managed services, access controls and monitoring may support the engineering team. Clarify responsibilities, current effort and requirements; neither lower costs nor compliance is established by moving to cloud services.

Worked example: Prepare the conversation

What happens for customers and your team when a promotion causes a traffic spike?
How do different teams use customer information today, and where do inconsistencies cause the most difficulty?
Which improvement would matter most over the next year, and how would you judge its success?
What concerns would you want addressed before evaluating a change to your current systems?
Who would need to be involved in discussing the priorities, budget and next steps?

Worked example: Prepare your first-meeting pack

Opening priority: website reliability. All sales go through the website, and promotions cause traffic spikes, checkout delays and occasional outages. These facts justify investigating the buying journey first.

Visual: Handling promotional traffic. Customer message: We would like to understand how peak traffic affects the buying journey and your team. Capacity that adjusts with demand is worth investigating, once the workload and application constraints are clearer.

Discovery question: When traffic peaks, where does the buying journey slow, and how does that affect customers and the team?

Claim review: qualify the line about flexible capacity resolving delays. The case does not establish every cause or the application changes required. Internal preparation: use the cost and disruption notes to identify effort, testing and specialist questions.

Next action and rationale: lead with reliability because every sale depends on the website. Ask for examples of peak-traffic problems and agree who can explain the application before investigating possible capacity options. A customer-information opening can also be sound when supported by the data and reporting facts.

Worked example: Leave a usable handover

Company: Sto Lat Select, an online-only home and lifestyle retailer with about 250 employees.
Needs / Challenges: peak-traffic delays and outages; inconsistent customer information; manual reporting; growing protection and maintenance demands.
Unknowns: impact measures, budget, decision authority, required controls and any migration deadline.
Internal alignment: prepare discovery questions about priorities and current systems; involve a technical colleague when requirements are clearer.
Possible direction: investigate elastic capacity, data integration and analytics, and managed-service options. No provider or architecture has been agreed.
Next step: prepare a discovery meeting and confirm who should attend. Agree responsibility and timing with the team rather than inventing customer commitments.
Notes: prepare a customer-facing one-pager and internal objection-handling and capabilities references. Keep the full question list with this record.

Keep your work and return

Retain your discovery summary and workbook. Review what you changed after comparing the example. Return to FutureLearn for the separate final course quiz and the showcasing-your-skills steps.